

The Fishbone Diagram

A picture that organizes every possible cause of a problem so your brain can actually work with it.

What It Is

Invented by Kaoru Ishikawa, the fishbone diagram puts the problem at the fish head on the right, with a spine running left. Big diagonal bones are categories of causes, and smaller bones are the specific causes themselves. It maps every possible reason your problem might be happening in one organized view.

The Six Ms

The classic categories are Method, Machine, Material, Manpower, Measurement, and Mother Nature. They are a thinking prompt that forces you to look under every rock. For an office process you might swap in People, Process, Technology, and Policy instead.

Where AI Fits

Describe your problem, give the AI the categories, and ask it to suggest causes under each one. It instantly breaks blank page paralysis with a rich, structured list. But it guesses from general knowledge and does not know your team, so it is a brilliant starting point and a terrible ending point.

Remember this

The fishbone forces you to slow down and think in every direction before you commit to one answer.